1. Executive Summary

The Naples City Parks & Recreation Department currently manages 13 parks, recreation centers, trails, beach access points, and signature waterfront destinations serving city residents as well as the region's considerable seasonal tourist visitation. Facing the challenges of coastal climate change impacts, seasonal population booms, aging facilities, and workforce instability, the City of Naples is presented with an opportunity to engage in a comprehensive planning process now more than ever. Internal work to-date which included a full system inventory, Level of Service (LOS) analysis, ParkServe analysis, and an assessment of the community's unmet needs for park and recreation design establishes that access to parks and recreation opportunities in the city is highly inequitable. Inland neighborhoods east of Goodlette-Frank Road are characterized by the most significant access gaps, lower amenities, least ADA spaces, and the highest reliance on pedestrian accessibility. These findings are consistent with national studies on park inequity (Rigolon, 2016; Trust for Public Land, 2024).

The primary stakeholders to be most impacted include year-round workforce households, renters, older adults, families in the River Park and Anthony Park neighborhoods, seasonal employees, and the visitor economy relying on a dependable and welcoming park system. The next 5–10 years will be crucial to enhancing walkability and equitable access, improving climate-ready infrastructure, establishing a seasonal workforce pipeline, and putting a transparent performance management framework in place (Hatry, 2019; NRPA, 2024a).

If we don't take action to these priority areas, inland inequities will deepen, recreation assets along the coast will face increased erosion and storm damage (U.S. Global Change Research Program, 2023), and visitor-facing service reliability will continue to be hampered by seasonal staffing gaps. The cost of doing nothing is public trust, less operational resilience, and greater long-term capital and maintenance costs. This is the ideal time to build off of this foundational internal work and turn it into a comprehensive, citywide planning effort.

2. Organizational Context

The Parks & Recreation Department's mission and strategic plan—dedicated to safe, equitable, and resilient recreation—tie directly to the city's climate adaptation plan and public health and livability goals (City of Naples, 2025). The city of Naples itself has two identities: a coastal tourist city and a small residential city with pockets of low-income families and higher-density areas inland. Parks and facilities systems range from massive coastal parks like Lowdermilk Park to community parks like Anthony Park and facilities and amenities like community centers and the Gordon River Greenway trail.

The city of Naples is a small coastal city with pockets of higher-density, year-round population, renters, and hospitality workers east of Goodlette-Frank Road who have less access to private swimming pools, playgrounds, and recreation facilities. Populations peak seasonally in the city, which has impacts on public spaces and seasonal employee availability. Key trends driving

change in the system include increasing coastal flooding and severe heat events and staffing issues due to the high cost of living. National emphasis on equity-focused park planning has also started to influence planning in recent years (Matheus, Janssen, & Maheshwari, 2020; NRPA, 2023).

3. Inventory & Existing Conditions

At the time of the agency's inventory, the agency had a portfolio of 18 publicly-owned parks and recreation facilities open to the public. Major characteristics of the existing park system included:

- Imbalance in regional distribution: Signature amenities and features concentrated west of US 41, inland neighborhoods relatively underserved.
- Inequality in access: Travel distances for inland residents, limited walkable accessibility, lack of multipurpose amenities
- Climate-vulnerable coastal assets: Naples Pier and Lowdermilk Park subject to repetitive storm damage, requiring costly resilience measures
- ADA limitations: Surfacing, ramps, and circulation routes may not be ADA compliant in some of the older neighborhood parks (ADA, 2010)
- Insufficient greenway connectivity: Naples has approximately 2.5–3 miles of greenway trail which falls short of NRPA benchmark recommendations
- Maintenance burden: Seasonal influxes lead to increased usage, wear, and demand for staff presence, which exceeds current workforce capacity.
- A two-tier system: the system has been described as "premium coastal parks vs. modest inland parks" which exacerbates park inequities (Cao et al., 2022)

ID	Name	Type (park/field/court/trail)	Primary Use	Location (address/area)	Condition (Good/Fair/Poor)	Size / Qty	Amenities	Accessibility (ADA notes)	Notes	Park Demand (Low/Med/High)	Potential for Expansion (Low/Med/High)
1	Cambier Park	Park	Signature park w/ bandshell, tennis, playground	755 8th Ave S	Good (playground closed pending replacement)	N/A	Bandshell; tennis center nearby; courts; picnic pavilion; restrooms; open lawn	Sidewalk access; central downtown setting; general ADA facilities; (playground currently closed)	Core downtown park hosting concerts/events; heavy visitation	High	Low
2	Fleischmann Park	Park	Athletics, playgrounds, skate park	1600 Fleischmann Blvd	Good	15 acres	Lighted racquetball; basketball/volleyball/pickleball courts; football/soccer fields; skate area; splash pad; playgrounds; pavilions; restrooms	Community center and facilities with accessible indoor spaces; paved circulation	Multi-age sports/rec hub; frequent programs and events	High	Medium
3	Lowdermilk Park	Park	Beach access, concessions, picnic	1301 Gulf Shore Blvd N	Good (ongoing coastal recovery context)	N/A	Beach; gazebos; picnic tables; sand volleyball; restrooms/showers; concessions	ADA beach access mats; designated accessible parking paths	High-use beachfront access; water quality/advisories monitored seasonally	High	Low
4	Naples Pier	Special Use	Iconic fishing pier + beach	25 12th Ave S	Fair (active rebuild/design program)	N/A	Pier; restrooms; showers; concessions; beach access	ADA beach access mat at beach; rebuilt elements planned in design	Pier under approved redesign concepts after storm impacts	High	Low
5	Baker Park	Park	Riverfront trail loop + fitness	50 Riverside Cir	Good (new park, opened 2019)	15 acres	Loop trail; river overlooks; pavilions; fitness stations; playground; splash features (status varies)	Paved paths; bridge to Greenway; site has accessible parking/routes	New riverfront destination connected to Greenway	High	Low
6	Gordon River Greenway	Linear Park / Trail	Riverfront boardwalk + trail	1596 Golden Gate Pkwy	Good	~140 acres; ~2.5 miles trail	Boardwalks; asphalt trails; wildlife viewing; access points; kayak launch	Paved/boardwalk surfaces; multiple accessible trailheads	Regional greenway spine; ecological corridor	High	Medium
7	Naples Zoo at Caribbean Gardens	Special Use Facility	Accredited zoo + botanical garden	1590 Goodlette-Frank Rd	Good	~43 acres	Main paved loop; shows; restrooms; concessions; gardens; animal exhibits	Paved primary paths; accessible restrooms; wheelchair spaces at theater	AZA-accredited; strong conservation/education use	High	Low
8	River Park Community Center	Recreation Center	Gym, pool, programs, playground	301 11th St N	Good	~11,000 sq ft building + outdoor	Computer lab; fitness room; auditorium; meeting rooms; pool; basketball pavilion; playground	Indoor accessible facilities; accessible pool amenities; paved campus	Neighborhood anchor in historically underserved area	High	Medium
9	Anthony Park	Neighborhood Park	Playground, basketball, open lawn	150 13th St N (area near River Park)	Good (neighborhood park scale)	N/A	Playground; courts; picnic tables; riverside setting; small dock (per city/visitor info)	Paved routes; level site; basic ADA parking access	Small local park serving River Park neighborhood	Med	Low
10	Arthur L. Allen Tennis Center	Special Use Sports	Clay courts + pro shop	730 8th St S	Good (well-maintained Hydro-Grid courts)	12 Har-Tru lighted courts	Chickee shade huts; cold-water fountains; pro shop; programs/USTA play	Accessible spectator areas and routes within Cambier complex	Regionally notable public tennis center	High	Low
11	Norris Community Center	Recreation / Cultural	Theater, classrooms, events	755 8th Ave S	Good	Multi-room facility	Auditorium/stage; meeting rooms; art gallery; classes; amphitheater	Purpose-built civic venue; accessible entrances/interiors	Downtown cultural programming hub next to Cambier	High	Low
12	Seagate Beach Access	Beach Access	Neighborhood beach walkover	Seagate Dr (North Gulfshore Access)	Good	N/A	Beach access; small parking lot (county); path to beach	Beach access path; at-grade walks; limited amenities	Serves Seagate/N. Gulfshore area; parking constrained	Med	Low
13	Clam Pass Park	Beach & Preserve	Boardwalk, mangroves, concessions	465 Seagate Dr	Good	35 acres; ~0.75-mile boardwalk	Tram/boardwalk to beach; restrooms; concessions; chair/cabana rentals	Paved segments/boardwalk; accessible tram to beach	High-demand coastal access with preserve setting	High	Low
14	Riverside Circle Boat Ramp	Boat Launch	Public canal boat launch (city)	Near 50 Riverside Cir (see note)	Fair (limited capacity/area)	N/A	Small ramp/launch area (assumed city); parking limited	At-grade access; basic facilities (assumed)	Listed locally but primary city launch is Naples Landing	Med	Low
15	Freedom Park	Passive / Memorial	Stormwater preserve + trails	1515 Golden Gate Pkwy	Good	~50 acres	Boardwalks/paths; interpretive signage; wetlands vistas; memorial elements	Paved/boardwalk paths; accessible viewing areas	Water-quality/flood-mitigation park with education	Med	Low
16	Bayfront Park Plaza	Plaza / Open Space	Hardscape plaza + events	Bayfront Dr (Bayfront district)	Good	N/A	Waterfront promenades; brick pathways; retail/food adjacency	Paved, step-free promenades; curb ramps; structured parking	Privately led mixed-use public realm; events potential	Med	Low
17	Sugden Regional Park	Special Use Lakefront	Lakefront paths, sailing, playground	4284 Avalon Dr	Good	60-acre Lake Avalon	Beach; sailing/waterski programs (incl. adaptive); playground; path; pavilions; restrooms	Paved loop path and amenities; adaptive sailing programs	Regional lakefront recreation and programming	High	Low
18	NAACP Youth Park	Neighborhood Park	Playground, shelter, open grass	River Park area	Good (community pocket park)	N/A	Play area; small shelter; open lawn (community use)	Paved neighborhood sidewalks; basic ADA access	Neighborhood-scale asset supporting youth activities	Med	Low

Visual One: Map of Inventory & Existing Conditions

4. Level of Service (LOS) & Benchmarking

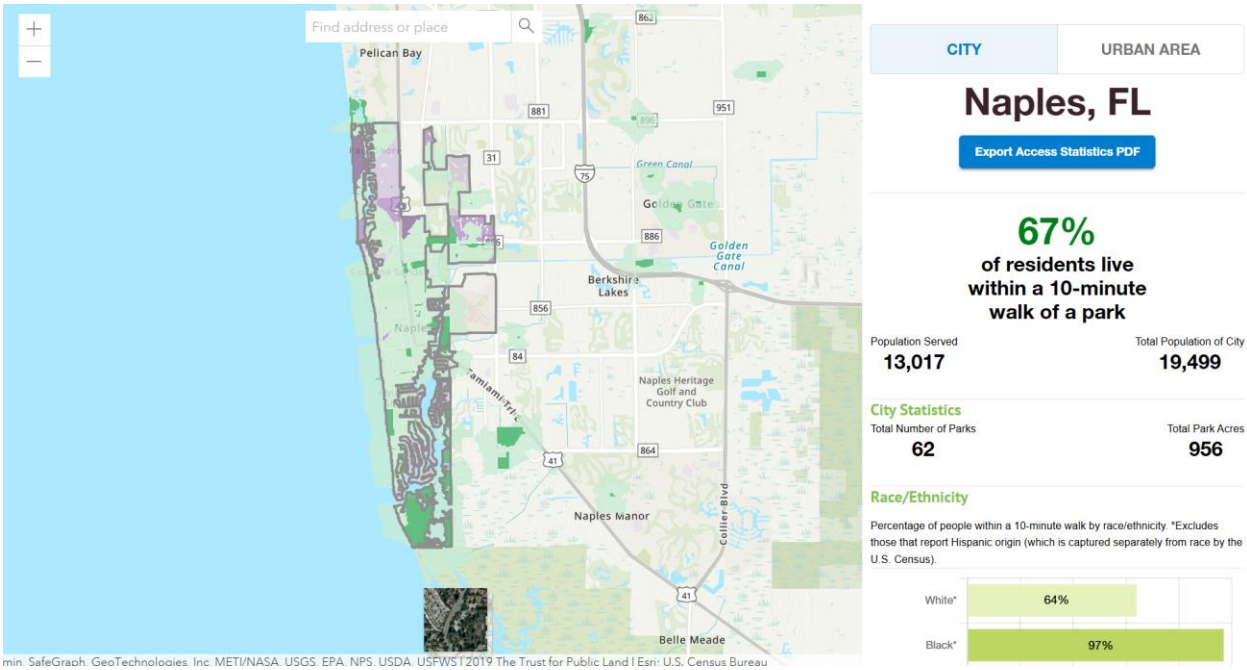
TPL ParkServe, NRPA Park Metrics, and peer comparison data analysis resulted in these LOS findings:

- Walkable park access: ~62% of residents have walkable access within 10 minutes; TPL's 75% is their national benchmark (Trust for Public Land, 2024).
- Inland gap: One inland cluster of 700+ residents lacks any walkable access.

- Greenway LOS: Naples has ~0.27 miles per 1,000 residents. NRPA's benchmark is ~0.46 miles (NRPA, 2024a).
- ADA LOS: 55–60% of amenities meet ADA accessibility. Gaps are most evident in inland playgrounds and older parks.
- Facility distribution: Complex amenities, such as tennis centers, large playgrounds, and event facilities, are heavily focused along the coast.
- Performance accountability: Naples has no formal system in place to track uptime, participation, or equity KPIs.

Gap Summary:

The most glaring gap is the structural inland access inequity. The inventory and ParkServe modeling corroborate each other in identifying that Naples must prioritize inland investment for a more balanced, equitable, and resilient system.



Visual Two: ParkServe 10-Minute Walk & ParkEvaluator Impact Map

5. Stakeholders & Engagement Plan

Primary Stakeholders:

- Year-round residents
- Seasonal residents/tourists
- Seasonal workforce (hospitality, maintenance, recreation)
- Parks & Recreation staff
- City leadership (Council, City Manager)

- Local schools (collaboration and joint-use potential)
- Environmental and conservation groups
- Accessibility/disability advocates
- Businesses and hospitality employers
- Partner agencies (Public Works, Planning)

Engagement Plan:

- Pop-up events at Fleischmann Park and Lowdermilk Park (City of Naples Parks & Recreation Department, n.d.)
- Bilingual and large-print surveys and materials
- QR code outreach for rapid digital engagement
- "Dot vote" priority boards and comment maps
- Listening sessions in underserved inland communities
- Youth ambassadors recruited through local schools and FGCU
- Seasonal worker input corner (private and facilitated feedback)
- Transparency measures including "You Said. We Did." reports (Hatry, 2019)
- Quarterly updates via public-facing dashboard (Matheus et al., 2020)

6. Strategic Themes & Priorities

Theme 1: Access, Equity & Resilient Connectivity

Addresses inland–coastal divide. Creates more walkable, inclusive system. Includes greenways expansion, ADA accessibility, reducing heat- and flood-related barriers, and targeted capital improvements inland.

Theme 2: Workforce Sustainability & Reliable Operations

Strategies focused on reliability and continuity of services to reduce seasonal workforce disruption. With Naples' heavy reliance on seasonal labor, these efforts included strengthening staff pipelines, cross-training, and service reliability metrics. (NRPA, 2024b)

Supporting Priorities:

- Climate-ready design (living shorelines, elevated structures)
- Facility modernization
- Maintenance and asset management consistency
- Transparent reporting/performance dashboards
- Community-centered programming

7. Partnerships & Funding Opportunities

Potential Partners:

- Trust for Public Land (park access, land acquisition, GIS support)
- Collier County Public Schools (joint-use agreements)
- FGCU and other local colleges (workforce pipeline)
- Environmental nonprofits (resilience solutions)
- Private sponsors (amenity sponsorships, shade structures)
- State and federal resilience agencies
- Local businesses and tourism industry

Potential Funding Tools:

- TPL 10-Minute Walk Campaign technical assistance and grants
- CIP funds for ADA and facility improvements
- Sponsorships/naming rights for specific amenities
- Resilience and coastal adaptation grants (USGCRP, state coastal programs)
- Fee-based revenue for specialty programs, balanced with equity goals
- Joint-use cost sharing with school district partners
- Foundations and donor contributions for health and wellness initiatives

8. Internal vs. External Capacity

Internal Capacity

- Parks & Recreation Department can complete the following tasks internally:
- Updating inventory data documentation
- First pass ADA walk-through evaluations
- Pop-up community engagement
- Fixing scheduling/workforce shortfalls
- Mocking up dashboards/basic KPI framework
- Aligning to operational policy, direction

External Consultant Needs

A consultant is needed for the following:

- LOS forecasting with GIS (Matheus et al., 2020)
- Climate risk modeling/resilience plan/design
- In-depth equity analysis (heat/flooding/demographic overlays)
- Cost estimating/capital programing
- Completion of a full strategic plan document
- Site-specific concept plans (inland park/Naples Pier redevelopment)

- Neutral/facilitated large-scale engagement phases

Rationale: These activities require more time than internal staff have available or require specific tools/modeling/computer work or a neutral third-party facilitator.

9. Initial Recommendations

- Create an inland neighborhood park or greenway connector through the current 700+ resident gap to expand the current 62% population walkable access rate closer to the Trust for Public Land's (2024) national goal of 75%.
- Add 1–2 additional miles to the Gordon River Greenway to improve mobility, shade access, and build resilient connectivity.
- Bring the two parks per year toward the 80% compliance in 10 years through ADA (2010) accessibility updates. (See Appendix)
- Create a seasonal workforce pipeline through partnerships with local schools, universities, and employers to improve retention and operational stability.
- Pilot a public performance dashboard to monitor uptime, access equity, program participation, resiliency conditions, and workforce reliability.
- Require climate-ready design standards for future capital projects to defend public access and control long-term costs (U.S. Global Change Research Program, 2023).

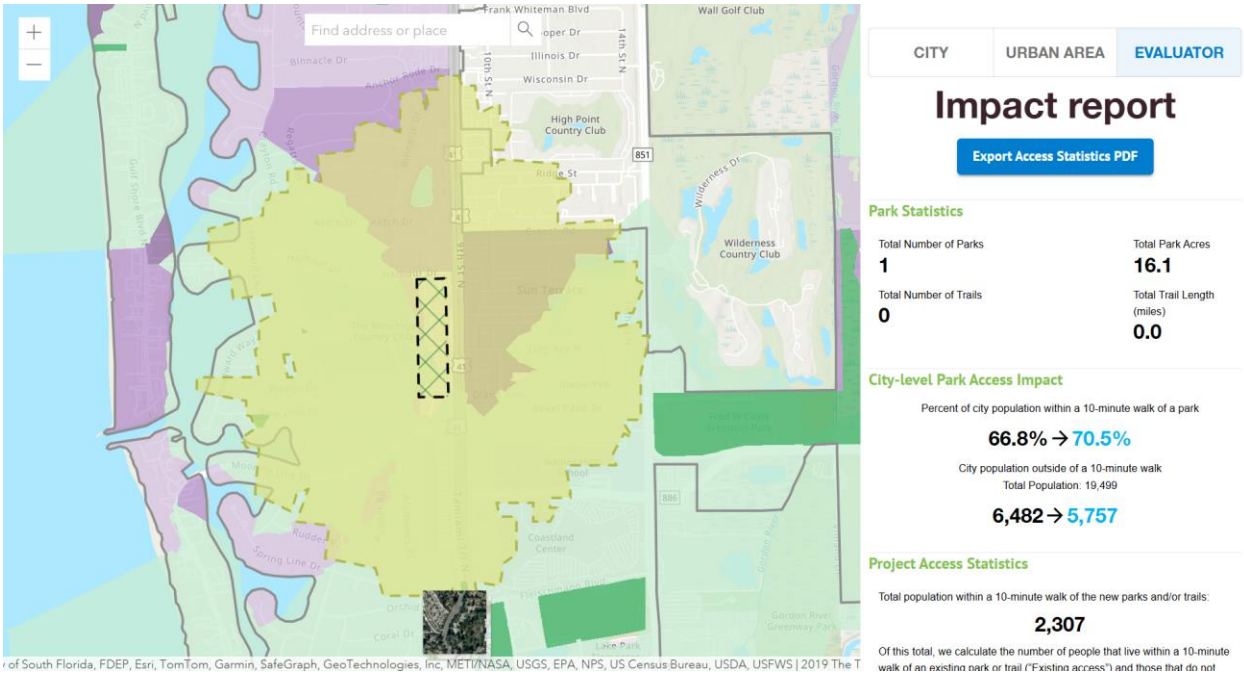
10. Future Sites & Site-Specific Needs

Priority Site:

- Inland park/trailhead east of Goodlette-Frank Rd (identified through both the inventory and the ParkServe modeling)

Additional Sites Needed:

- Naples Pier: Ongoing climate-resilient redevelopment
- Lowdermilk Park: Coastal recovery/erosion mitigation, shade and heat island adaptations
- River Park Community Center: ADA upgrades, expanded programming space



Visual Three: ParkEvaluator projected access gains map

11. Conclusion

The research we have completed this semester has shown that Naples' parks system is suffering from systemic inequities, climate vulnerabilities, and operational issues tied to employee reliability. The inland–coastal split has been quantifiable, repeatable, and stable across multiple datasets, validating a critical need for policy realignment. The City of Naples should proceed now to avoid further divergence, uphold its national identity as a coastal resort, and invest in resilient infrastructure that benefits year-round residents.

TPL and outside experts will help with the development of a complete planning process that will allow the City to implement advanced analytics, generate defensible recommendations, and design a long-term investment framework based on performance and equity outcomes. The involvement of City leadership is imperative and partnerships with schools, nonprofits, and regional agencies will be integral to its successful implementation.

TPL's planning process will position the City of Naples to issue a robust, data-driven RFP for services and embark on a comprehensive transformation of its parks system over the coming decade.

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